Experience and comparison

What can people's experience and other places' attempts tell us that numbers cannot?



Today

By the end of today, you will have

Built a comparative case matrix and drawn themes from published qualitative sources.

- Draw themes from published qualitative sources such as audits, social audits, testimony and field studies.
- Compare how two or more places tackled a similar problem.
- Identify the conditions that made an approach work, and which of them transfer.
- Use qualitative evidence to test mechanisms, not just to illustrate.

Competencies: E5 · E6

Session plan

10 min	**Opening problem**
20 min	**Concept: qualitative evidence**
20 min	**Demonstration: comparing cities**
30 min	**Activity: policy transfer challenge**
30 min	**Studio: own comparison**
10 min	**Debrief and exit task**

Opening problem

- **Indore has repeatedly been ranked among India's cleanest cities. Should Madhyapur simply copy Indore?**

Before you answer, list what you would need to know about Indore and about Madhyapur.

What published qualitative evidence can do

1

Reveal mechanisms

How did crews, households and officials actually behave? Audits and field studies often show the why behind the numbers.

2

Record absent voices

Social audits, testimony to committees and field studies record people the data do not reach.

3

Test a story

A mechanism that appears in several independent sources is stronger than one that appears in one.

This course uses published qualitative evidence only. No interviews or surveys.

Coding sources into themes (illustrative, for Madhyapur)

Theme	Where it appears	Supports or weakens
Crews mix streams when paid by weight	An audit finding; a newspaper report; two city case studies	Supports H1
Households stop separating when they see mixing	A field study of resident behaviour	Supports the H1 mechanism
Waste pickers recover dry waste where they are integrated	Studies of cooperative models	Weakens H3 for those cities
Fines without monitoring raise dumping	Reports from two other cities	Supports the H4 rival

A theme carries weight only when at least two independent sources support it.

A comparative case matrix

Feature	Indore	Pune	Ambikapur
What was done	Separated door-to-door collection, enforcement, sustained campaigns	A waste pickers' cooperative integrated into door-to-door collection	Women's self-help groups running collection and sorting centres
What helped	Leadership sustained across years	An organised union and a municipal partnership	Small scale and state support
What might transfer	Campaign and enforcement design; scale of spending uncertain	Partnering with pickers for dry waste, if they are organised	Ward-level centres in smaller wards

Widely documented cases. Verify each description against your sources before using it.

Policy transfer: what travels and what does not

Travels poorly

- Leadership and political commitment
- An organised partner, such as a union or federation
- Scale, budgets and existing infrastructure

Travels more easily

- A design principle, such as paying for separated collection
- A process, such as ward-level monitoring
- An institutional form, if local actors exist to fill it

Ask what made it work there, and whether those conditions exist here.

Copying the form without the function

- **A city can copy Indore's vehicles and slogans without its enforcement, monitoring and leadership. That is the form without the function.**

This is the isomorphic mimicry trap from Day 5, met again in comparative evidence.

Activity: The policy transfer challenge

Judge whether an intervention that succeeded elsewhere would work in a different context.

Scenario

A state wants to copy a neighbouring state's apparent success in reducing teacher absence through biometric attendance, community monitoring and fewer non-teaching duties for teachers. Each pod compares the two stylised states on the conditions that made it work in the first.

What to do

1. List the components of the intervention.
2. For each, list the conditions it depended on in the original state.
3. Check whether those conditions exist in the adopting state.
4. Classify each component: transfers, transfers with adaptation, or does not transfer.
5. Write one paragraph on what to copy and what to build first.

Time 30 minutes

Groups Pods of four

Output A transfer judgement for each component

Your case: Worksheet 5.3

Comparative and qualitative evidence

1. Find two or three places that tackled a problem like yours, using published sources.
2. Fill the comparative matrix: what was done, what helped, what transfers.
3. Code at least three published qualitative sources into themes.
4. Mark each theme as supporting or weakening a hypothesis.
5. Add every source to the evidence register.

Hand in

Worksheet 5.3 by the start of Day 14.

Quality check

Two or three comparison places.

Tag every claim in your Analyst's Ledger: fact, inference, assumption or hypothesis.

What to take away

1. Published qualitative evidence reveals mechanisms and voices that numbers miss.
2. A theme carries weight when independent sources agree.
3. Ask what made an intervention work there, and whether those conditions exist here.
4. Copy functions, not forms.

Exit task Name the condition that most limits transfer to your case.

Before the next session

Independent work

Prepare for the red team: write your three strongest findings so far, each with its two best sources. About 50 minutes.

Read

Dolowitz, David P., and David Marsh. "Learning from Abroad: The Role of Policy Transfer in Contemporary Policy-Making." Governance 13, no. 1 (2000).

Next

Day 14: Testing the hypotheses

Tomorrow your hypotheses face the evidence, and a red team.